Processor Trends

Example

A story of nonlinear growth (Ed Catmull, 2020 ACM Turing Award)
In 1979 Catmull wanted to make a digital movie : it would have needed the power of 1000 CRAY-1 supercomputers (10 million US$ each), with a budget of 1M$. Based on the exponential curve of computing speed, he estimated it would take another 14-15 years : "Toy Story" came out about 15 years later, very close to the estimate.

Key idea

50 years of microprocessor trends ("Moore's Law") : the number of transistors keeps growing, but frequency and single-thread performance have flattened.

— We hit a **power wall at ∼100 W/cm^2** : frequency is fixed because raising it increases power usage & temperature.
— Our processors aren't getting much faster anymore.
— The only thing we can do is to have **more processors** (multi-core CPUs, GPUs).

Summary

Why this history lesson ?

— The only way to get good performance nowadays is to anticipate how an algorithm will run on a particular piece of hardware and then *design for it*.
— Sometimes : use a good implementation of a common building block (e.g. a matrix factorization by Intel/NVIDIA). When your needs are more special, you will likely have to make it yourself.
— Order-of-magnitude speedups are easy to get.

Warning

You don't have to learn C++ or assembly code for the CS328 final exam, but you should know that these things exist and how they *roughly* work.

Model Problem : psum

Definition

psum(x) : sum the positive elements of the input vector `x`. A simple operation, but one that isn't "natively" supported by NumPy.

Tip of the iceberg : below the Python code (browser, Jupyter, NumPy, bytecode interpreter, OS) lie instruction decoding, Tomasulo's algorithm, speculative execution, caches and prefetch, DRAM, physical bits. On a GPU : CUDA/Vulkan, kernels, hardware scheduler, shared memory, latency hiding.

Python bytecode : `dis.dis(psum)` shows the stack-machine instructions (`LOAD_FAST`, `BINARY_SUBSCR`, `COMPARE_OP`, …).

Key idea

Dissecting the interpreter : a big loop fetches the next *opcode* and jumps to one of ∼130 code blocks. `COMPARE_OP` pops two operands, calls `PyObject_RichCompare` (stack overflow check, type dispatch, reference counting, error management), down to `float_richcompare` ("Comparison is pretty much a nightmare").

— That's *a lot* of code for something so simple : the overhead dwarfs the actual operation.
— Inherent compromise of an interpreted language. Overheads are usually negligible when the operation does more work.

Example

Vectorization in Python
Bad : a Python loop `if B[i] < 0: X[i] = A[i] + C[i] else: X[i] = A[i] + D[i]`
Good : `X = A + np.where(B < 0, C, D)`

First Version in C++

Example

```
float psum_0(float *x, size_t size) {
  float r { 0.f };
  for (size_t i = 0; i < size; ++i) {
    if (x[i] >= 0) {
      r += x[i];
      if (std::isinf(r))
        abort();
    }
  }
  return r;
}
```

Everything has types : `float` (single precision), `size_t` (64-bit integer), `float*` (pointer to a float array). Glued to Python with **nanobind**.

Definition

DISASSEMBLER
Reveals the processor instructions ("assembly code") in a compiled executable (IDA Home, Ghidra). Used here to understand the performance differences between `psum` versions.

The disassembly of `psum_0` shows a loop of `LDR` (load), `FCMP` + `B.LT` (compare and branch), `FADD`, the infinity check (`FABS`, `FCMP`, `B.EQ`), then the loop counter.

Pipelining, Latency and Throughput

Example

Laundry day : 3 batches (Dark, Light, Color), 3 steps (Wash, Dry, Fold). Naive schedule : 9 cycles. Better (pipelined) schedule : **4 cycles**.

Definition

LATENCY : number of cycles before the result of an operation is available.
THROUGHPUT : number of operations that can be started per cycle.

Key idea

Pipelining within processing units : a unit split into 5 stages has latency 5 but throughput 1 (one new input per cycle); with 5 independent inputs it keeps all stages busy.

Key formulas

Intel "Ice Lake" (1 cycle on a 3 GHz CPU = 0.33 ns; light moves 10 cm)

Instruction	Latency	Throughput
`int64` integers		
add, sub	1	4
mul	3	1
div	15	1/14
`float32` vectors		
add, sub, mul	4	2
div	17	1/10

Throughput 4 : can start 4 additions every cycle. 1/14 : busy for 14 cycles before new input can be accepted. **Loading memory, division and square root are really expensive.**

Superscalar Execution

Definition

TOMASULO'S ALGORITHM ("superscalar execution")
Aggressively parallelizes the execution of a program : instead of running it step by step, try to do everything at once while respecting data dependencies. Processing units must wait for their inputs to be ready ("reservation stations").

- LOADs are **extremely** slow : helpful to do multiple in parallel.
- Newer architectures (e.g. Apple M1) look at the eight next instructions per clock cycle; in a loop, they can run ahead several iterations.
- The CPU is like a high-speed train : to keep the pipeline fed, it must look far ahead (decode, schedule and execute different instructions at the same time).

Definition

BRANCH PREDICTION
At each branch, the processor must decide what to do a long time in advance (waiting would be too slow) : ask the oracle (jump or not ?), go that way and begin executing; N cycles later we know if it was right. Correct : all good. Wrong : pull the emergency brake and undo all steps.

Warning

In the naive `psum_0`, mispredictions happen all the time : the input values are random and positive with 50% probability.

Example

Improved version (no branch) : `for (...) r += fmaxf(x[i], 0.f);` – compiled to `FMAXNM` + `FADD`.

SIMD and Partial Sums

Definition

SIMD (single instruction, multiple data)
CPUs can process vectors : in the same amount of time, add $x[0]+y[0]$ or 16 elements at once. Accessible through **intrinsics** (Intel/AMD : SSE, AVX, AVX512 ; ARM : NEON, SVE).

Warning

The idea was that compilers would magically insert vector instructions ("auto-vectorization"). It never really worked, and still does not work well enough.

Key idea

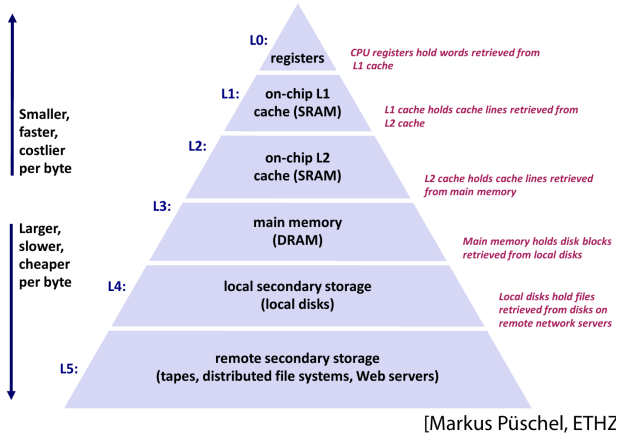
What's missing ? Each SUM depends on the previous SUM : the program is still not parallel enough to keep the pipeline fed. Break these connections : compute **4 (or 8 or 16) partial sums** and add them up at the end (`psum_3` : 4 vector accumulators).

Memory & Caches

Key formulas

Load instruction : latency ∼5-300 cycles, throughput 2. Depends on where we go in the memory hierarchy : registers, L1, L2 (SRAM), main memory (DRAM), local disks, remote storage – smaller, faster, costlier per byte at the top.

Typical Memory Hierarchy



[Markus Püschel, ETHZ

Definition

Temporal locality : the same memory is accessed again soon.
Spatial locality : nearby memory is accessed soon.
Prefetchers exploit spatial & temporal regularity : after a few misses on a regular access pattern, loads become hits.

Example

Cache hit : get something predictable from the corner store. **Cache miss** : weird unpredictable access, wait a long time (but can order multiple packages in parallel).

Key idea

CPUs vs GPUs : multiple instructions per cycle, huge caches, branch prediction, speculative execution… GPUs don't have it! A CPU is a cheetah; a GPU is an army of snails : each core much simpler, smaller and slower, but lots of them.

Summary

General advice – when optimizing, be wary of

— sacrificing correctness for speed (ensure correctness first, e.g. tests);

— reinventing the wheel (use the right tools, libraries);

— valuing computer time over your own time (maybe optimization isn't needed).

Always measure : most time is spent in a few bottlenecks; locate them and focus on them.